

## WEEK ONE, IN ORDER

# Learn the business before you learn the product

New PMs are handed a wiki, a backlog and a calendar full of intros, and they start with the wiki. It is the worst of the three. The wiki was written by people who already understand the business, for people who already understand the business. It assumes the exact context you do not have yet.

The sales deck was written to explain the company to a stranger. In week one that is what you are. Start where the explaining already happened, then work inward.

Here is the order, and what to actually look for in each one.

## 1 The sales deck, twice

Ask whoever onboards you for the deck the team uses with new customers. Not the internal strategy deck. The one a salesperson opens in front of someone who has never heard of the company.

Read it once for the story. Read it again for the claims. The second pass is where the useful part is, because every claim in a sales deck is a promise your product has to keep.

### EXAMPLE

Write down every promise the deck makes. That list is your real backlog, whether or not it matches the one in the tracker.

**WHY THIS MATTERS:** you will be asked to prioritize long before you understand the system. The promises the company already made are the highest-signal input you have in week one.

## 2 The pricing page

Public, free, and nobody reads it. Pricing tells you what the company actually charges for, which is frequently not the same as what it says it sells.

Look at what sits behind the highest tier. Look at what is free. The gap between them is the business model in one screen.

### EXAMPLE

Write one sentence: "We make money when a customer does X." If you cannot finish it, you have not found the model yet. Keep looking.

**WHY THIS MATTERS:** product decisions that look irrational from the inside are usually rational once you know where the money comes from. Learn the money first and half the confusion disappears.

### 3 The last two quarterly updates

This is where strategy stops being a slogan and turns into a number someone is accountable for. You are looking for two things: what leadership said would happen, and whether it did.

Also read what they stopped talking about between the two. A priority that quietly disappears tells you more than one that gets repeated.

#### EXAMPLE

List the three metrics that appear in both updates. Those are the only metrics that are real. Everything else is decoration.

**WHY THIS MATTERS:** your work gets judged against whatever those numbers are doing, not against the roadmap you were shown in your interview.

### 4 The org chart, then the real one

Get the formal chart first so you know the names. Then spend two weeks working out the actual one, because they are different documents.

The real chart is drawn by watching who gets asked before a decision is made, whose objection stops something, and whose name comes up when nobody wants to say no directly.

#### EXAMPLE

After each intro meeting, write one line: who does this person need in the room to say yes. After twenty meetings you have the real chart.

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**WHY THIS MATTERS:** proposing the right thing to the wrong person is the most common way a good first project dies quietly.

### 5 One recorded sales call

Almost no new PM does this, and it is the single highest-yield hour of week one. Ask sales for one recording of a call that went well and one that did not.

You will hear the customer describe the problem in their own words, and you will hear which parts of your product they did not care about at all.

#### EXAMPLE

Write down the exact phrases the customer used. Use their words, not the internal names, for your first month of writing. It signals immediately that you have been outside the building.

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**WHY THIS MATTERS:** your engineers and your stakeholders have both heard the internal version a hundred times. The customer's version is the only thing you can bring that nobody else in the room already has.

None of this is about being impressive in week one. It is about being able to tell, in week five, whether the thing you are being asked to build makes any business sense.

Read outward in, and start with the document written for a stranger.